

SOFTWARE / APPS

APP RATINGS



User app ratings are just pure garbage. Users are liable to give the app a one star if they hate it, and five stars if they love it, and there's just no consistency. Most apps have ratings spikes at the two extremes. In effect, end users have no realistic objective rating for how good an app is, which is supposedly the purpose of the rating system. Then there is a problem of skewed ratings for the more obscure apps. Studies have shown that it is better to just trust apps with more reviews – any kind of reviews at all – than apps that have fewer reviews, irrespective of how highly they have been rated. It is possible to game the rating systems through the use of tools such as Amazon's Mechanical Turk. There have been several efforts to fix the rating systems over the years, but none of them seem to have worked. For example, a seriously bad game, X-Files: Deep State has a rating of 4.6 on the Play Store. We do not want to speculate on what is going on over here, but this is a clearly misleading rating. Interested readers can find out more about exactly why the application sucks in the Mobile Madness section in SKOAR!

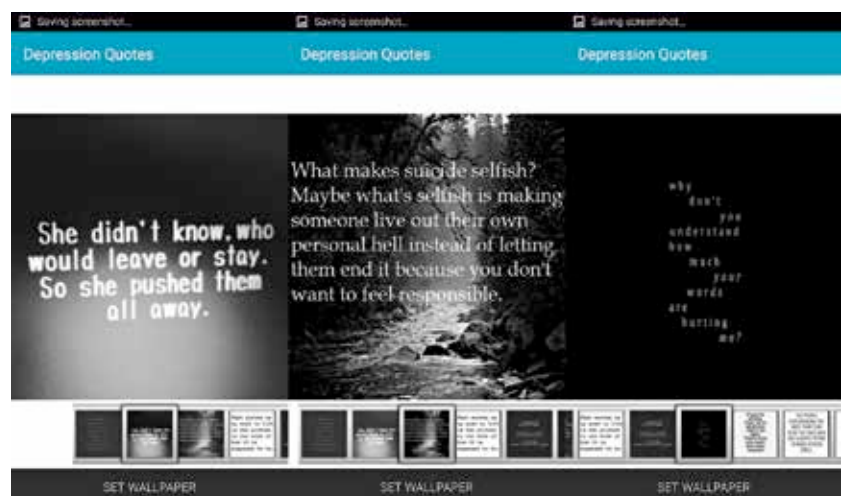
MENTAL HEALTH APPS



This is one of the scary aspects of the application stores. There are a number of mental health applications that practically prey on vulnerable people who are in need of actual help. Search for “depression” or “anxiety” and you get a large number of applications that promise ways to improve your mood, hypnotise you out of panic attacks, and even “remove brain fog”. The problem is that these applications are not really created by mental health professionals, and are likely to do more harm than good. One of the apps that claims to be based on scientific approaches, merely shows different colours in an effort to improve your mood by displaying just the right sequence of shades. There are genuine mental health apps, that have been cre-

ated by researchers, healthcare professionals and universities. However, these applications too are experimental. Even the creators do not yet fully know how effective the apps are, and acknowledge it. In fact, because of their experimental nature, they can actually have unintended consequences. The Swedish government came up with an app that calculates blood alcohol concentration based on the number of drinks a person had consumed. The application was meant to

running on the latest versions of the devices and operating systems. At times, apps can disappear from some regions for mysterious reasons, even after you purchase them. An example of such an app is the sidescrolling platformer, *Project 83113*. There is no real solution for this. If you are actually spending money on the application stores, enjoy the app as much as you can while it still works. No one can give a guarantee of how long your purchases will still be functional.



You are not helping, app.

reduce drinking. Instead, users of the application ended up drinking more. If you need help, go to a professional, do not expect any from an application just yet.

DISAPPEARING APPS



The problem with making purchases from application stores is that you never really know how long those purchases will last. At the time of the purchase, it is taken for granted that the application will always be available on the store, and that the latest device or OS can actually run it. That is not the case. Even a wildly popular title like *Plants Vs Zombies* was silently removed from the app store. OS and store updates means that a number of applications already installed on the devices no longer start up, and you cannot re-install your previous purchases. The onus is on the developers here to keep the apps up and

Not the marketplaces, not the developers, and not the device manufacturers.

REGIONAL RESTRICTIONS



Some applications and services are not available in India. If it is a content streaming service, we can understand considering that the services have to have enough local and regional language content, as well as work through copyright issues. However, when it is something like Twitch Prime, or just a game, there is absolutely no reason why a piece of software should not work in India. Heck, Twitch Prime is even available in Bangladesh! Amazon Prime users in India have already paid for the service. Almost every site or service that says “This service is not available in your country”, is doing itself a disservice by not tapping into one of the largest markets in the world.